

What defines Ashwin is his openness to suggestions

I particularly enjoyed keeping when **Ashwin bowled to left-handed batters** from around the wicket.

Wriddhiman Saha

When I made my Test debut in February 2010, Harbhajan Singh was spearheading India's spin department, along with Amit Mishra. However, later that year, as I broke into the white-ball team, I met a bright, confident, young off-spinner who was also taking his first steps in international cricket.

We were around the same age, and back then, I obviously had no clue that over the next 11 years, we would go on to feature in 38 Test matches together, with 215 of his wickets coming when I was the wicketkeeper.

Throughout my career, I dealt with quite a few quality spinners, who carried the mystique associated with the art. But I have no hesitation in admitting that it was my old friend Ravichandran Ashwin whose off-spin challenged me the most.

I would not use the word "difficult"; rather, his deliveries were tricky to read. Unlike most spinners of his time, Ashwin's variations in length added to the challenge. Standing behind the stumps, I realised that spinners need to be read right from the hand, and if you could do that, half the job was done. The remaining part involved making adjustments based on the bounce and turn. Keeping up to 'Ash', as we fondly call Ashwin, boosted my confidence and helped me read spinners better.

While he tormented the batters, Ashwin was also one of the finest all-rounders of our times. Time and again, he

has proved his mettle with the bat. I also have some really special memories of batting with him.

How can I forget our long stand — 213 runs for the sixth wicket — against West Indies in Gros Islet? Back in 2016, both of us went on to score centuries in that Test, and that partnership still remains India's second-highest in an away Test. **As we batted along, Ashwin walked up to me repeatedly to ensure we were thinking along similar lines.** As we approached our nineties, our conversations increased, and Ashwin made sure I wasn't feeling the pressure en route to my maiden century. Throughout my career, Ashwin, Jaddu (Ravindra Jadeja), and I rotated our batting orders — me at No. 6, Ashwin or Jaddu at No. 7 or No. 8 — so our understanding improved, and we got to know each other better. Batting in the lower middle order has its own challenges, but I am glad that Ashwin, Jaddu, and I could forge partnerships whenever the team needed. These are memories I will cherish forever.

I find it hard to believe that Ashwin will no longer be donning the